

COPING WITH STRESS

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Maintain a program of recovery free from addiction and excessive anxiety.
2. End the use of addictive behavior as a way of escaping anxiety, and practice constructive coping behaviors.
3. Decrease anxious thoughts and increase positive, self-enhancing self-talk.
4. Learn to relax and to think accurately and logically about events.
5. Identify effective stress management methods that are already working.
6. Incorporate stress management as part of a lifestyle change and identify areas in which to begin modifying stress responses.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE ANXIETY

- Coping with Addiction and PTSD or Other Anxiety Disorders
- Correcting Distorted Thinking
- Handling Crisis
- Identifying Relapse Triggers and Cues
- Learning to Self-Soothe
- My Anxiety Profile
- Safe and Peaceful Place Meditation
- Using Books and Other Media Resources

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Medical Issues
- Relapse Proneness

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Coping With Stress” activity examines the client’s existing stressors and habitual responses, with the aim of increasing his/her insight and assisting him/her in reducing stress and improving coping skills. It includes an imagination exercise aimed at motivating the client to work for improvement and bolstering his/her confidence in doing so. Follow-up might include homework assignments to practice new stress management methods identified through this or other exercises; seeking feedback

from family, friends, and others on perceived changes in the client's degree of tension; and reporting back to the therapist and/or group on outcomes. Encourage clients to locate classes or groups in their communities in yoga and/or other relaxation strategies.

COPING WITH STRESS

At least one-third of relapses in recovery from addictions are triggered by stressful situations, because many of us have used addictive behaviors as our main tools for handling stress. We have two choices: (1) find a way to guarantee we will never again experience stress, or (2) find different ways to handle it. The purpose of this exercise is to guide you in learning about your own stress management style, your sources of stress, and how you can manage stress differently and more effectively.

1. Please describe a situation in which you used alcohol, another drug, or another addictive behavior to cope with stress.

2. What connections do you see between stress and addictive patterns in your life?

3. What kinds of situations cause you the most stress? Please list three situations that commonly trigger great stress for you.

4. How can you tell when you are experiencing stress in your life? Please list your reactions to stress, both physical and emotional.

5. What are your usual ways of handling stress? Include both positive and negative strategies.

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6. Please talk with some people who know you well and whom you feel have good judgment, people you trust to give you straight answers. Ask them to describe, in a phrase or short sentence, what they have seen as your usual reactions to stress. Write their answers here.

7. Many times, we walk straight into stressful situations we could have bypassed, or we fail to use effective ways to cope that we know we could use. List causes of stress you can control in the first column, and things you can do to avoid or cope with them in the second column.

8. Other times, a situation may be unavoidable, but we increase the stress we experience because of the ways we think about that situation (e.g., predicting terrible outcomes to ourselves, worrying about things we can't change). List causes of stress you cannot control in the first column, and ways you can change your thinking about them in the second column.

9. Please describe a stressful situation that you handled well and how you did it.

10. You can reduce your level of stress by avoiding overdoing things in any area of your life. This can reduce the stress you experience and help you do better at handling what stress remains. Please list at least one thing you can do today to create more balance in each area listed here.

a. Relationships with family or friends:

b. Leisure time/activities:

c. Work/school:

d. Community involvement:

e. Spiritual activities:

f. Diet:

g. Exercise:

h. Emotions:

11. What are three healthy coping methods you can use anytime, anywhere, when confronted with stressful situations in your recovery?

12. Exercise in imagination: Picture yourself in the future, handling a stressful situation using different and more effective methods than you would have used when you were practicing an addictive coping style. What improvements do you see in the results and your quality of life as a result?

What are you already doing differently, and what can you start doing now, to change your present situation to the one you imagined?

While you picture yourself living this way, pay attention to how this image of yourself makes you feel. Talk about this with other members of the treatment group or in your next treatment session.

Be sure to bring this handout back to your next session with your therapist, and be prepared to talk about your thoughts and feelings about the exercise.